SAFE

Cooling cooked potato salad quickly and refrigerating within 2 hours helps prevent bacterial growth. Consuming within 3-4 days reduces risk of spoilage and pathogens.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

SAFE

Washing fresh fruits under running water removes dirt and potential surface microbes, reducing the risk of contamination from handling or environmental sources.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

NOT SAFE

Garlic in oil at room temperature creates an anaerobic environment favorable for Clostridium botulinum growth and toxin formation; it must be refrigerated and used quickly.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

NOT SAFE

Leaving cooked food in the temperature danger zone (40-140°F) for more than 2 hours allows rapid bacterial growth and increased foodborne illness risk.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

NOT SAFE

Poor sanitation and starting with spoiled vegetables increase risk of growth of harmful pathogens like Clostridium botulinum during fermentation.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

IT DEPENDS

Safety depends on the drying process and final moisture: properly dried jerky and vacuum-sealed can be room temperature stable, but incomplete drying or warm temps risk bacterial growth.

Source: SP 50-1000 Turkey basics

IT DEPENDS

At altitudes over 1,000 feet, water boils at lower temps, so processing time or pressure must be adjusted for safe acidity and pathogen control in home canning.

Source: Troubleshooting canning acid foods

IT DEPENDS

The safety of homemade salad dressings depends on their acidity and refrigeration. If the dressing is sufficiently acidic (pH 4.6 or below) due to lemon juice and other acidic ingredients, and it is kept refrigerated, it can be safe for several days. However, if the acidity is borderline or other ingredients reduce acidity, bacteria may grow, making it unsafe to keep for 5 days. Always consider the pH, ingredients, and temperature.

Source: SP 50-834 Tips for critical thinking

SAFE

Using fresh, firm fruit that is carefully washed and peeled reduces spoilage risks. Hot packing and processing peaches in a boiling water canner for the correct time ensures destruction of harmful microorganisms. Adjusting processing time for altitude is important for safety and quality.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

SAFE

Filling jars with boiling water and packing raw cherries following tested recipes ensures safety. Proper headspace and processing in boiling water canners destroy molds and yeasts and create a vacuum seal that prevents spoilage.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

NOT SAFE

Plums are borderline acidity fruits and often require added acid for safe boiling water canning; otherwise, a pressure canner is required. Using unverified recipes and omitting acid addition risks survival of botulism-causing bacteria.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

NOT SAFE

Filling jars with raw fruit into jars that are not hot can cause jar breakage and poor seals. Additionally, waiting many hours before processing allows spoilage organisms to multiply, increasing risk of unsafe product.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

NOT SAFE

Processing times must be increased with altitude because boiling water is at a lower temperature at higher elevations. Using sea-level times at high altitude risks underprocessing, which can cause spoilage or pathogen survival.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

IT DEPENDS

The safety of canning peaches with no sugar depends on whether the syrup provides enough acidity and correct processing time is adjusted. Sugar is not a safety factor but sugar or acidic syrups can help preserve quality. Using tested recipes for low or no sugar syrups and following processing times is important.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

IT DEPENDS

Asian pears have borderline acidity and typically require acid addition (like lemon juice) to safely process in boiling water canners. Safety depends on the variety's acidity and following a tested recipe. Without acidification, using a pressure canner might be necessary.

Source: SP 50-694 Preserving asian pears

IT DEPENDS

Asian pears are lower in acid than other pear varieties, so USDA and OSU guidelines recommend adding lemon juice to each jar to ensure safe acidity levels during boiling water canning. Without added acid, the safety depends on whether the lemon juice or other acidifying step is included. If lemon juice is omitted, the product may not be safe because pathogenic bacteria like Clostridium botulinum could survive. Therefore, safety hinges on whether the acid is added before processing.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

SAFE

Using a tested salsa recipe with the right acidity level and processing time in a boiling water canner at the correct altitude prevents the growth of harmful bacteria, including botulism. Vinegar at 5% acidity and following time and temperature guidelines ensure safety.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

SAFE

Using high-quality tomatoes, peeling and coring them properly, heating salsa to boiling, and processing jars with the correct headspace and time in a boiling water canner meets safety standards. These steps help destroy harmful bacteria and ensure acidity is sufficient.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

NOT SAFE

Tomatoes must be acidified by adding lemon juice or citric acid before canning to ensure a safe acidity level that prevents botulism. Relying on natural acidity alone is unsafe as tomato pH can vary and sometimes be too high (less acidic).

Source: PNW 300 Canning tomatoes and tomato products

NOT SAFE

Increasing fresh garlic or herbs before canning alters the recipe's acidity, potentially lowering it and making the salsa unsafe. Only use tested recipes without altering acid ingredients, as botulism risk depends on acidity level.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

NOT SAFE

Raw-packed tomatoes without added acid do not reach safe acidity levels and may not process to eliminate bacteria. Tomatoes should be acidified and preferably hot-packed (heated) before water bath canning to ensure safety.

Source: PNW 300 Canning tomatoes and tomato products

IT DEPENDS

Lime juice can substitute bottled lemon juice in some recipes, but not always vinegar. Vinegar and citrus juices differ in acidity. If the original recipe calls for vinegar, substituting lime juice may alter acidity and safety unless confirmed by research. The safety depends on recipe testing and correct acid levels.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

IT DEPENDS

Altitude affects boiling temperature and thus processing time. At higher altitudes, longer processing times are needed to ensure safety. If Anna's process time at sea level is too short for 5,500 feet, the salsa might not be safe unless time is appropriately increased.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

IT DEPENDS

Because some vegetables are low-acid foods, including non-acidified vegetables in salsa requires pressure canning for safety, not boiling water canning. The safety depends on the recipe being tested specifically for mixed vegetable salsa and using the correct canning method.

Source: PNW 172 Canning vegetables

SAFE

Green beans are low-acid foods and must be processed in a pressure canner to prevent botulism. Following tested recipes with correct pressure, time, and altitude adjustments ensures the product is safe.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

SAFE

Freezing corn after proper blanching is a safe preservation method. Blanching stops enzyme action, and freezing halts microbial growth without safety risks typical to canning low-acid foods.

Source: SP 50-443 Preserving corn

NOT SAFE

Green beans are low-acid foods that require pressure canning to destroy Clostridium botulinum spores. Water bath canning does not reach the temperatures needed for safety, making this process unsafe.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

NOT SAFE

Salsa is a mix of acid and low-acid ingredients. Without using a tested recipe ensuring correct acidity and processing, botulism risk is high. Vinegar amount and processing methods must be precise.

Source: PNW 395 Salsa recipes for canning

NOT SAFE

Garlic in oil is low-acid and an anaerobic environment where botulism spores can grow. Without acidification or refrigeration, this storage method is unsafe and can cause botulism.

Source: SP 50-701 Herbs and vegetables in oil

IT DEPENDS

Pressure and processing time must be adjusted for altitude. If Anna's altitude adjustment is incorrect, the internal temperature may not reach levels needed to kill botulism spores, making the stew unsafe. Correct altitude adjustments ensure a safe product.

Source: PNW 361 Canning meat poultry game

IT DEPENDS

Proper fermentation produces acid that prevents botulism. However, storing fermented low-acid vegetables in an airtight container without temperature control can be risky if acid production was insufficient or temperature is too warm, allowing harmful bacteria growth.

Source: PNW 450 Canning smoked fish at home

SAFE

Susan used a tested recipe with proper vinegar acidity (5%), which is crucial for safety in quick pickles. Using fresh ingredients and soaking cucumbers in ice water helps keep pickles firm and safe. Immediate processing and proper storage further ensure safety.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

SAFE

Refrigerating pickled eggs promptly and consuming them within a recommended time frame reduces the risk of harmful bacteria like Clostridium botulinum. Hard-cooked eggs pickled in vinegar form a safe acidic environment.

Source: NCHFP Pickled eggs

NOT SAFE

Reducing vinegar decreases acidity, which can allow harmful bacteria to grow. The acidity level must be maintained as per tested recipes to ensure food safety. Altering vinegar amounts without adjustment is risky.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

NOT SAFE

Using non-food-grade lime and failing to thoroughly rinse it off can leave excess lime, which is unsafe for consumption. Only food-grade pickling lime should be used and cucumbers rinsed multiple times as directed.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

NOT SAFE

Unprocessed jars of pickled vegetables stored at room temperature risk growth of spoilage and pathogenic bacteria. Heat processing in boiling water or pressure canner, depending on the recipe, is necessary to ensure safety.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

IT DEPENDS

The safety of Anna's pickles depends on whether the recipe is tested to ensure at least 5% vinegar acidity and proper processing. Without verified acidity and processing instructions, the pickles could be unsafe.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

IT DEPENDS

Cloudiness can be caused by hard water or powdered spices and does not necessarily mean unsafe pickles. If recipes, acid level, and refrigeration are correct, cloudy brine might be a quality issue rather than safety. Verification is needed.

Source: PNW 355 Pickling vegetables

SAFE

Using a tested recipe with the correct balance of fruit, sugar, and acid along with proper boiling and processing in a water bath ensures safety by destroying spoilage organisms and preventing bacterial growth. Proper jar sterilization and timing are essential to form a safe, shelf-stable product.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

SAFE

Fresh berries combined with the correct amount of sugar and commercial pectin and stored frozen quickly provide a safe, high-quality jam without needing heat processing. Freezer jams must be kept frozen or refrigerated and eaten within recommended times for safety.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

NOT SAFE

Pepper jelly is a low-acid product and requires added acid to safely process in a boiling water canner. Without sufficient acid, harmful bacteria like Clostridium botulinum can grow, especially if the processing time is too short to kill pathogens.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

NOT SAFE

Making jelly without added pectin requires precise acid and sugar balance and cooking times; simply boiling for a long time cannot guarantee safe gel or microbial stability. Without tested pectin use or acid adjustments, the jelly may not be safe for long-term storage.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

NOT SAFE

Mold on high-moisture foods like jam can penetrate beneath the surface and may be accompanied by harmful bacteria or toxins. Scraping off mold does not make the jam safe to eat. The jam should be discarded to avoid foodborne illness risk.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

IT DEPENDS

Low-methoxyl pectin jams rely on added acid to maintain safety. Reducing acid may raise pH above safe levels, risking bacterial growth. Safety hinges on whether the acidity remains below pH 4.6 after adjustment. Careful pH testing or following exactly tested recipes is required.

Source: SP 50-632 Making berry syrups at home

IT DEPENDS

Processing times must be increased at higher altitudes because water boils at lower temperatures. Using unadjusted standard times may not adequately destroy pathogens. Safety depends on whether Emily adjusts processing time for her altitude following guidelines.

Source: PNW 199 Canning fruits

SAFE

Cooling hot foods in shallow containers before freezing helps them chill quickly and safely, reducing bacterial growth. Keeping the freezer at or below 0°F (-18°C) ensures food remains safe for long-term storage. Labeling and dating help rotate older foods first, maintaining quality.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables

SAFE

Wrapping fish tightly to exclude air prevents freezer burn and quality loss. Freezing promptly when the fish is fresh preserves flavor and texture. Portioning allows removing only what is needed, avoiding repeated thawing. These practices maintain both safety and quality.

Source: PNW 586 Home freezing seafood

NOT SAFE

Thawing ground beef at room temperature allows bacterial growth on the surface before the inside thaws. The USDA and OSU recommend thawing meat in the refrigerator, cold water, or microwave to keep temperatures safe.

Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home

NOT SAFE

Freezing canned foods can damage seams causing bulging and spoilage. If the cans bulge and thaw to room temperature, bacteria may have grown and the food becomes unsafe. Cans with intact seams thawed safely are generally okay to use.

Source: PNW 296 Freezing convenience foods that you've prepared at home

NOT SAFE

Freezer burn happens when air reaches food, causing quality loss, dryness, and off-flavors. While not making the food unsafe, it seriously degrades quality. Using air-tight packaging and removing excess air minimizes freezer burn and preserves quality.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables

IT DEPENDS

Blanching is generally recommended for vegetables but not usually for pumpkin puree. Freezing cooked pumpkin puree directly is safe if cooled and packaged properly. However, if freezing raw pumpkin pieces, blanching preserves quality better.

Source: SP 50-713 Storing pumpkin winter squash

IT DEPENDS

Shrimp held above 40°F for more than 2 hours can grow harmful bacteria. At 45°F for 3 days, the shrimp is likely unsafe. Refreezing shrimp kept properly at 40°F or below and still containing ice crystals is safe, but above that temperature it is not.

Source: PNW 214 Freezing fruits and vegetables

IT DEPENDS

Eggs should be kept at or below 40°F to slow bacterial growth. At 42°F, the eggs are slightly above recommended temperature, which may reduce shelf life but short-term use within a week is likely safe. Prolonged storage above 40°F increases risk.

Source: PNW 720 Proper egg handling

SAFE

Drying fruits at temperatures around 140°F until the fruit is leathery but not brittle, then storing them in airtight containers away from heat and light, preserves food safety and quality for home use.

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables

SAFE

Smoking meat at controlled temperatures with tested recipes ensures salt penetration and heat destroy pathogens. Maintaining smokehouse temperatures above 130°F and following reliable curing procedures produces safe, flavorful smoked meats.

Source: PNW 784 Making bacon at home

NOT SAFE

Drying raw meat at too low a temperature or without precooking does not reliably kill harmful bacteria like Salmonella or E. coli. Meat jerky must be precooked or heated to at least 160°F to be safe.

Source: PNW 632 Making jerky at home safely

NOT SAFE

Smoking fish at temperatures below 130°F risks pathogen survival and bacterial growth. Maintaining a consistent temperature above 130°F is critical to safety, as lower temperatures may allow dangerous bacteria to grow.

Source: PNW 238 Smoking fish at home

NOT SAFE

Drying herbs in a humid or poorly ventilated space risks mold growth and spoilage. Safe drying requires good airflow, low humidity, and moderate temperatures to prevent unsafe moisture retention and botulism risk.

Source: SP 50-921 Drying herbs

IT DEPENDS

Drying tomatoes is safer with a pre-treatment like lemon juice or ascorbic acid to preserve color and reduce spoilage risk, especially for slicing tomatoes with lower acidity. Safety depends on the acidity and drying method used.

Source: PNW 397 Drying fruits and vegetables

IT DEPENDS

Smoking summer sausage at low temperatures without a final cooking or curing step may not kill pathogens. Safety depends on using tested cured recipes, maintaining proper temperature, and applying a heat step or fermentation as required.

Source: SP 50-735 Summer sausage deli style meats